Public contracts in Portugal, goods and services, 2019–2026

1,298 public contracts were signed between €19,999 and €20,000.

I loaded every contract on Portal BASE, 1.55 million of them, to see where the values sit. The legal limits leave a clear mark.

The rule

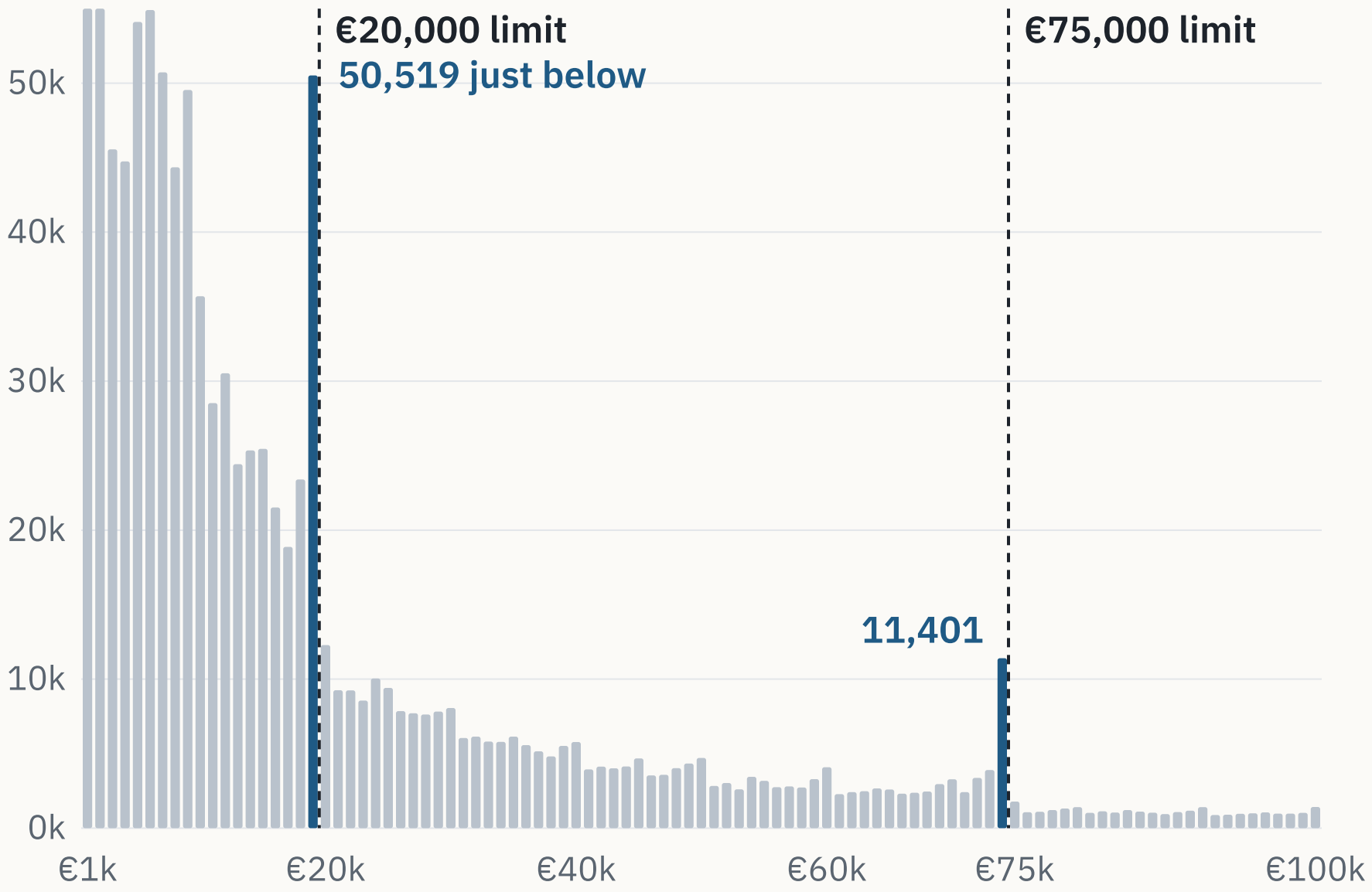
Up to €20,000, a public body could buy goods and services by direct award.

No tender needed. Up to €75,000, it could invite a few suppliers (prior consultation). Above that, more process and more time.

Limits from the Public Contracts Code in force until 30 September 2026. New limits apply from 1 October 2026, so this analysis stops there.

Goods and services contracts by value, €1,000 bands

The bar just below each limit stands out.



1.32 million contracts between €0 and €100,000, Jan 2019 – Sep 2026. Bars under €10,000 are cut at the top. Source: Portal BASE (IMPIC), dados.gov.pt.

In numbers

€19,000 – €19,999	**50,519**
€20,000 – €20,999	**12,290**
Average of the 8 bands around it	**15,796**

3.2× more contracts just below €20,000 than nearby.

The same happens at every limit: 5.2× below €75,000 for goods and services, 4.5× below €30,000 and 5.6× below €150,000 for public works.

What this does not say

The data shows where values sit, not why.

A buyer who sets the budget at the limit, a supplier who prices to the ceiling, or a purchase split in parts all draw the same shape. Telling them apart needs the contract files, not a chart.

What the chart does well: it shows an auditor or a buyer where to look first.

How I built it

- Open data from Portal BASE, 2019 to October 2026
- Python to load it, DuckDB and dbt to model it: 20 models, 100 tests
- The same model in Power BI, Qlik Sense and a web dashboard
- Private individuals are never named; a test fails the build if one appears

The live report is in the Featured section of my profile.